

founded in the early 1970s, operates Historic Latta Plantation. "It's a good partnership," said Toler. "The county can keep up their historic site without having to pay for it, basically. They give us an operating grant, and we're also funded by the Arts & Science Council, but most of what we run on is income through admissions, special events and school groups."

These days, 12,000 students visit

Historic Latta Plantation on a yearly basis. Through school trips, summer camps and special events such as the Ghostwalk in the fall and the candlelight Christmas tour in December, children as well as adults glean bits of the past from Historic Latta Plantation.

Jean Boggs, whom Historic Latta Plantation's visitors center is named for, was instrumental in preserving the property during the 1970s and couldn't



Latta Plantation Nature Preserve includes the Carolina Raptor Center, home to 100 resident birds and attracting almost 50,000 visitors a year.

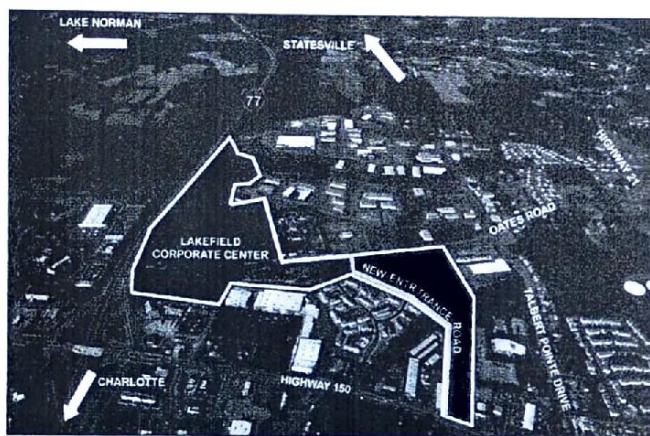
be happier about the site's popularity. "I believe that the past and our history is important if we want to learn how to conduct ourselves in the future," said Boggs, who lives in Charlotte's Myers Park neighborhood. "That's sort of a cliché, but if you don't know where you've been, you don't know where you're going."

Through the work of Boggs and many others, Latta Plantation Nature Preserve is now a destination, as it also includes the Carolina Raptor Center (which is home to 100 resident birds and attracts almost 50,000 visitors a year), the Latta Plantation Equestrian Center and the Latta Plantation Nature Center. Horseback and walking trails run rampant through the preserve, and Segway tours are also offered with a reservation.

"I can remember at the dedication," recalled Boggs, "it was a beautiful day and all the northern county people who were so proud came up to me after that dedication and said, 'You know this is the first thing of any importance that's ever been constructed or created here in our part of the county.' They were so pleased about that, and that made me feel so good because there are so many wonderful people up there. I thought that they should be represented." ■

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